



Global Entertainment & Media Outlook 2026–30: India perspective

**India's entertainment and media sector
moves from scale to monetisation**





About the report

PwC's Global Entertainment & Media Outlook is its flagship thought leadership report that provides a detailed analysis of consumer and advertising spending across the entertainment and media (E&M) industry in 53 countries. Covering ten revenue segments and a data consumption segment, the report provides a comprehensive overview of market dynamics and future trends shaping the E&M landscape.

The India perspective of the Global Entertainment & Media Outlook 2026–30, titled '**India's entertainment and media sector moves from scale to monetisation**', provides an in-depth analysis of India's E&M industry. The industry is evolving beyond its traditional growth narrative. For over a decade, the sector's expansion was fuelled by rapid digital adoption, affordable data, rising content consumption, and one of the world's youngest consumer bases. This phase established India as one of the fastest growing and largest E&M markets globally. Today, however, scale alone is no longer sufficient.

Across the industry, media companies, advertisers, content creators, and platform operators are increasingly focused on extracting greater value from audiences rather than simply acquiring them. The report examines the future of the E&M ecosystem where the emphasis is shifting toward monetisation, premiumisation, regionalisation, and operational efficiency. Simultaneously, it highlights how investments in connectivity infrastructure and AI are creating new opportunities to generate revenue, improve consumer engagement, and enhance content creation.



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01

India's E&M landscape

India's E&M landscape is no longer defined by a single dominant format or platform. The convergence of traditional and digital ecosystems, the deepening of regional reach, and the emergence of technology-led value pools will collectively define the industry's growth through 2030 and beyond.

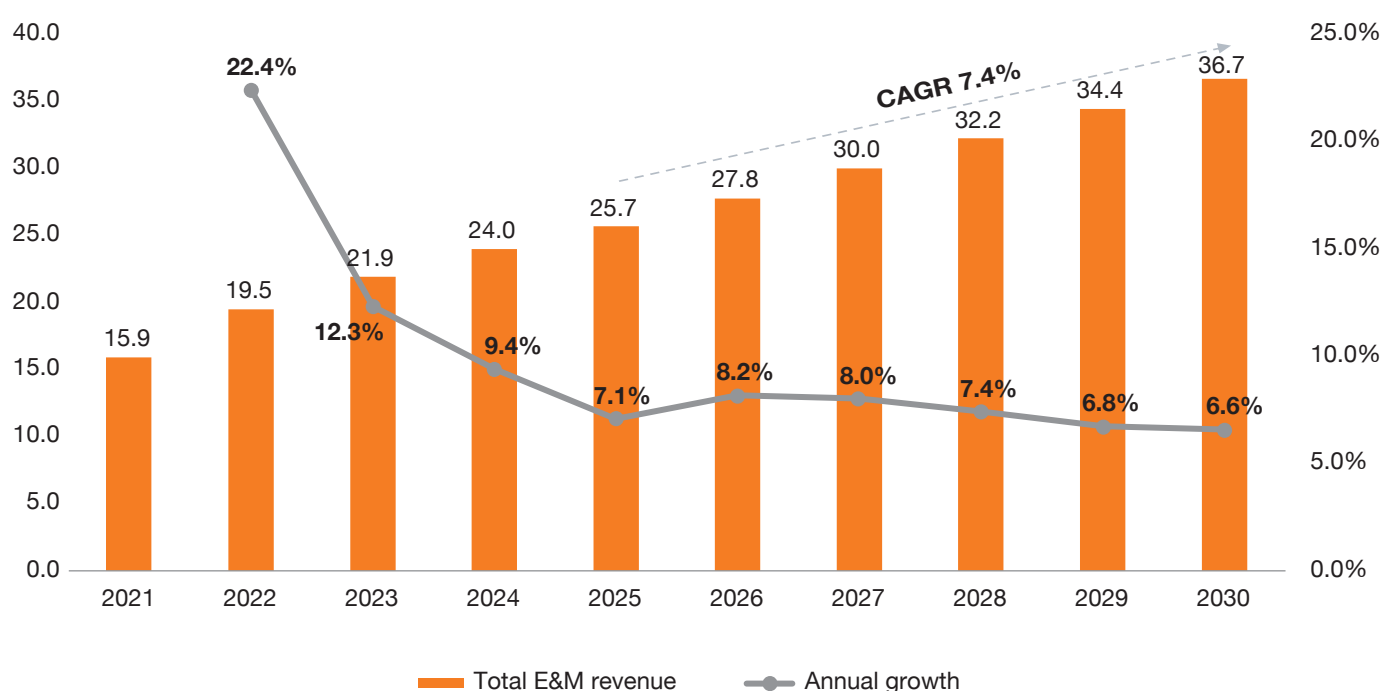
The industry remains on a strong growth trajectory, powered by expanding digital ecosystems and accelerating consumer adoption of online media. Growth is being driven primarily by internet advertising, OTT video, and gaming, which continue to outpace traditional media segments. While mature sectors such as television and print remain significant contributors to industry revenues, digital platforms are expected to account for a higher share of incremental growth through 2030.

Riding on the back of these factors, the total E&M revenue in India is projected to grow from approximately USD25.7 billion in 2025 to around USD36.7 billion by 2030—a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of about 7.4% over the forecast period.¹ By comparison, the global market is projected to grow at a 4% CAGR (2025–2030), reaching USD2.68 trillion by 2030 and adding USD 482 billion in new revenues, driven largely by digital ecosystems.

Meanwhile, in 2025, global E&M revenue reached USD2.1 trillion and is expected to grow a further 5.5% in 2026 to USD2.3 trillion.

Notably, between 2025–2030, India's E&M market is set to grow at nearly twice the global E&M growth rate of 4%, underscoring its position as one of the fastest-growing media markets in the world. This outperformance is supported by rapid digital adoption, expanding internet access, rising smartphone penetration, and a young, digitally native consumer base.

India's E&M revenue (in USD billion) and annual growth (%), 2021–2030



¹ Note: Unless cited otherwise, all data in this report is from the Global Entertainment & Media Outlook 2026–30: India perspective.

India outpaces global growth across most E&M segments (see Table 1 below). Domestic E&M growth is broad-based but digitally anchored with internet advertising (13.9% CAGR), video games and e-sports (11.3%), and OTT video (10.2%) among India's fastest-growing categories.

Furthermore, data connectivity is expanding rapidly, with accelerating 5G adoption, rising mobile subscriptions, and deepening broadband penetration bringing millions of new consumers online. This growing reach and reliability are directly fuelling the surge in digital consumption. As connectivity scales—projected to grow from USD36.5 billion in 2025 to USD58.6 billion by 2030 at a 9.9% CAGR—so does the market for every digital segment that depends on it.

Table 1: Segment-wise growth

Segment	India CAGR (2025–2030)	Global CAGR (2025–2030)
Internet advertising	13.9%	7.2%
OTT video	10.2%	6.1%
Video games and e-sports	11.3%	3.6%
Music, radio, and podcasts	6.8%	3.0%
B2B media	5.3%	2.0%
Out-of-home (OOH) advertising	2.9%	3.9%
Cinema	3.3%	3.4%
Traditional TV	1.0%	-1.1%
Print (newspapers, magazines and books)	3.2%	-0.5%



02

Key highlights


Internet advertising is expected to remain the strongest growth engine for India's E&M market

As advertisers follow audiences into an increasingly mobile-first, digital-native environment, internet advertising is set to remain the single largest driver of India's E&M expansion. Revenues are expected to nearly double—from USD7.5 billion in 2025 to USD14.3 billion by 2030, a robust 13.9% CAGR. This growth will be powered by paid search, video advertising, rising smartphone penetration, and accelerating digital ad investments as brands shift budgets toward measurable, high-engagement platforms.


Traditional TV growth bucks global trend

Despite mounting competition from digital platforms, traditional TV remains one of India's largest media segments, defying the sharp declines seen in more mature global markets. Total industry revenue is forecast to grow modestly from USD7.2 billion in 2025 to USD7.5 billion by 2030, supported by its extensive reach, a strong regional content ecosystem, and continued advertiser demand for mass-market audiences that digital platforms cannot yet fully replicate.


The games and e-sports market is forecast to be among the fastest-growing globally

The market is projected to expand from USD1.5 billion in 2025 to USD2.6 billion by 2030 at an 11.3% CAGR. This surge is fuelled by increasing smartphone adoption, low-cost mobile data, and rising gaming penetration. But the real inflection point lies in monetisation, as mobile gaming and in-game advertising evolve from engagement drivers into meaningful revenue streams.


While digital scales rapidly, traditional formats retain relevance

Traditional TV and print are declining globally (-1.1% and -0.5% respectively) but continue to grow modestly in India (1.0% and 3.2% respectively), underscoring the enduring role of legacy media in reaching the country's vast and diverse audience base.


Advertising-supported models are unlocking the next wave of streaming growth in the country

India's OTT market is projected to grow from USD2.2 billion in 2025 to USD3.6 billion by 2030, achieving a 10.2% CAGR. Growth will be supported by affordable mobile data, an expanding subscriber base, and strong demand for local content. However, the decisive lever will be the rise of advertising-supported streaming models, which are unlocking access for price-sensitive audiences and opening a new frontier of scalable, ad-led revenue.


Regional content and rising subscriptions are turning India into a streaming-first music market

Rising smartphone usage, expanding digital consumption, and the growing adoption of paid subscriptions are expected to drive digital music streaming revenues from USD380.1 million in 2025 to USD 639 million by 2030 at an 11% CAGR. The real catalyst, however, is regional-language content. By penetrating deeper into India's diverse linguistic markets, streaming platforms are converting a vast, previously underserved audience into an engaged and increasingly monetisable base.

Last year, the India edition of the Global Entertainment & Media Outlook 2025–29, titled ‘India’s E&M growth rides its youth wave’, focused on the country’s 910 million-strong millennial and Gen Z population and their growing demand for diverse, immersive, and personalised experiences. This year’s report takes the narrative a step further, examining how the industry is evolving from audience acquisition to audience monetisation. The next three chapters take a closer look at India’s rapidly evolving E&M landscape. Chapter 3 deep dives into the core building blocks of the E&M market, exploring how established and emerging segments are adapting, competing, and creating value. It covers traditional media, which is evolving through premiumisation and deeper digital integration; and digital media, where platforms are shifting their focus from audience acquisition to revenue optimisation.

Chapter 4 highlights how regional language content is fast becoming a primary engine of growth by unlocking India’s vast and diverse linguistic markets.

Chapter 5 uncovers the forces that will shape the next phase of India’s E&M story. It explores how connectivity infrastructure has become a critical enabler for the industry, how live experiences and premium entertainment are generating fresh spending pools, and how AI is beginning to transform the economics of media content creation and distribution.

Together, these chapters provide a comprehensive view of where India’s E&M market stands today and a forward-looking perspective on the emerging opportunities that will drive its next wave of growth.



03

India's E&M market has entered its monetisation era

India's E&M market has entered a phase where the focus is on converting reach into sustainable value. This shift is playing out across three interconnected fronts:

- Traditional media is evolving through premiumisation and deeper digital integration.
- Digital media platforms are moving decisively from audience acquisition to revenue optimisation, prioritising monetisation and profitability over pure growth.
- Regional language content is becoming a primary driver of growth. Companies are unlocking India's vast and diverse linguistic markets to turn previously underserved audiences into meaningful revenue pools.

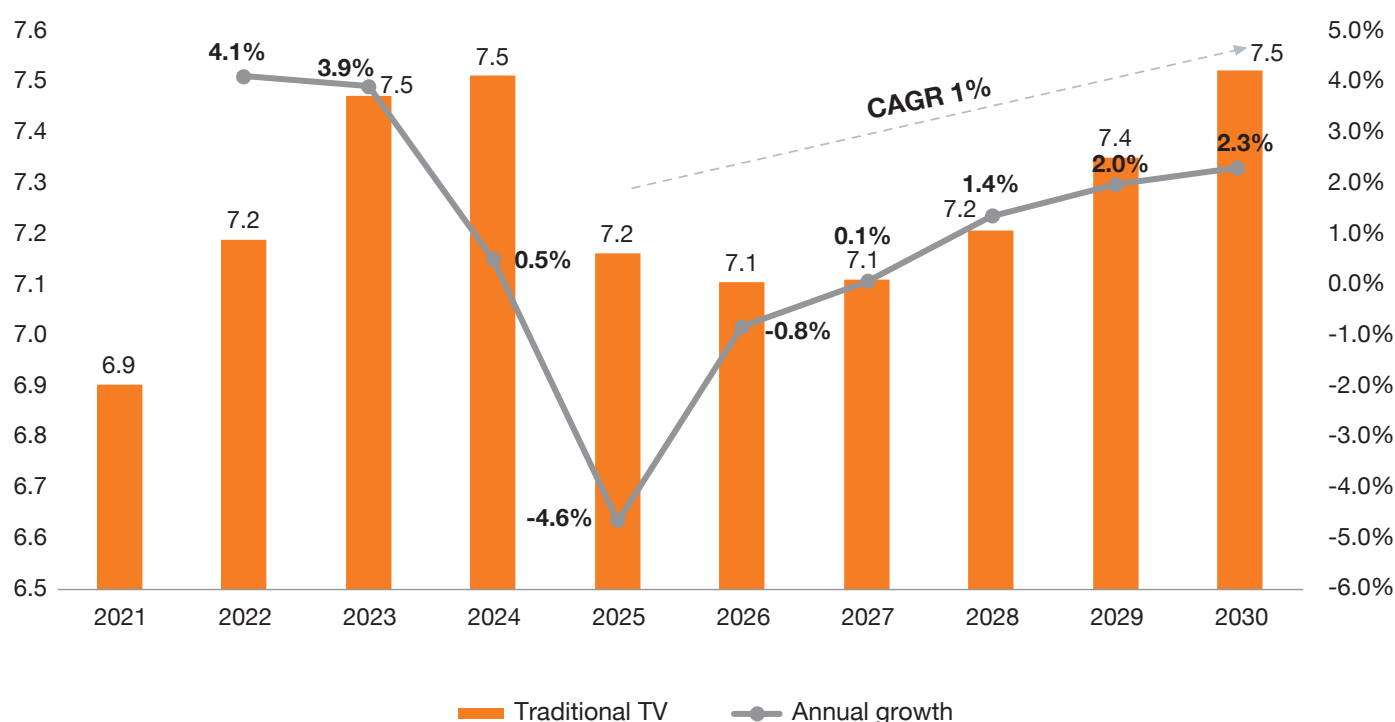
3.1 Traditional media

Television, newspapers, and cinema and outdoor advertising remain deeply embedded within India's media landscape. Rather than competing directly against digital channels, traditional media sectors are increasingly adopting digital capabilities, premium business models, and platform-based strategies. This convergence is allowing traditional sectors to remain relevant while leveraging many of the capabilities that have enabled digital growth.

Television stays strong as broadcasters evolve into integrated platforms

Television remains one of the largest and most influential segments within India's E&M landscape. Despite increasing competition from streaming platforms and digital video, India is one of the few major markets where traditional television is expected to remain broadly stable, generating USD7.2 billion in revenue in 2025 and growing to USD7.5 billion by 2030. The market continues to benefit from India's scale, linguistic diversity, and expanding middle class, ensuring that television retains a central role in the country's media ecosystem.



India: Traditional TV revenue (in USD billion) and annual growth (%), 2021–2030

A defining trend shaping the industry is aggregation and convergence. The merger of Disney’s Indian operations and Reliance’s media assets to form JioStar represents one of the most significant structural shifts in the market. By bringing together television networks, streaming platforms, premium sports, and digital content under a unified ecosystem, broadcasters are increasingly positioning themselves as integrated media platforms rather than standalone TV operators. This convergence reflects a broader industry shift towards combining broadcast and streaming assets to strengthen audience reach, content offerings, and monetisation opportunities.

Sports remains a key driver of this strategy. Through ownership of valuable International Cricket Council (ICC) and Indian Premier League (IPL) rights, JioStar has strengthened its ability to aggregate audiences across both television and streaming platforms. At the same time, the company has announced increased investment in local content production, particularly in South India, highlighting the growing importance of regional content in attracting and retaining viewers across multiple platforms.

While viewers increasingly consume content across multiple screens, television continues to offer advertisers one of the largest mass-reach platforms in the country. In 2025, broadcast television advertising generated USD4.2 billion, making it the largest advertising format across television categories. Advertising revenues in this category are forecast to increase to USD4.6 billion by 2030, supported by television’s continued ability to deliver scale and broad audience reach.

Local and regional content underpins the continued growth of television. Channels broadcasting in Hindi, Marathi, Tamil, and Telugu continue to dominate viewing, with Hindi-language programming accounting for approximately half of broadcast television content. Established formats and locally relevant programming remain important audience drivers, reinforcing the enduring importance of regionalisation within India’s media landscape.

At the same time, the industry faces increasing competition from digital platforms. YouTube has emerged as a significant disruptor, with reported daily viewing time reaching 72 minutes per user in 2025, highlighting the growing convergence between traditional television and digital video consumption. As viewers continue to embrace streaming and on-demand formats, broadcasters are increasingly adopting hybrid strategies that combine linear television, OTT services, and digital distribution to remain relevant in a rapidly evolving media environment.

Key takeaway

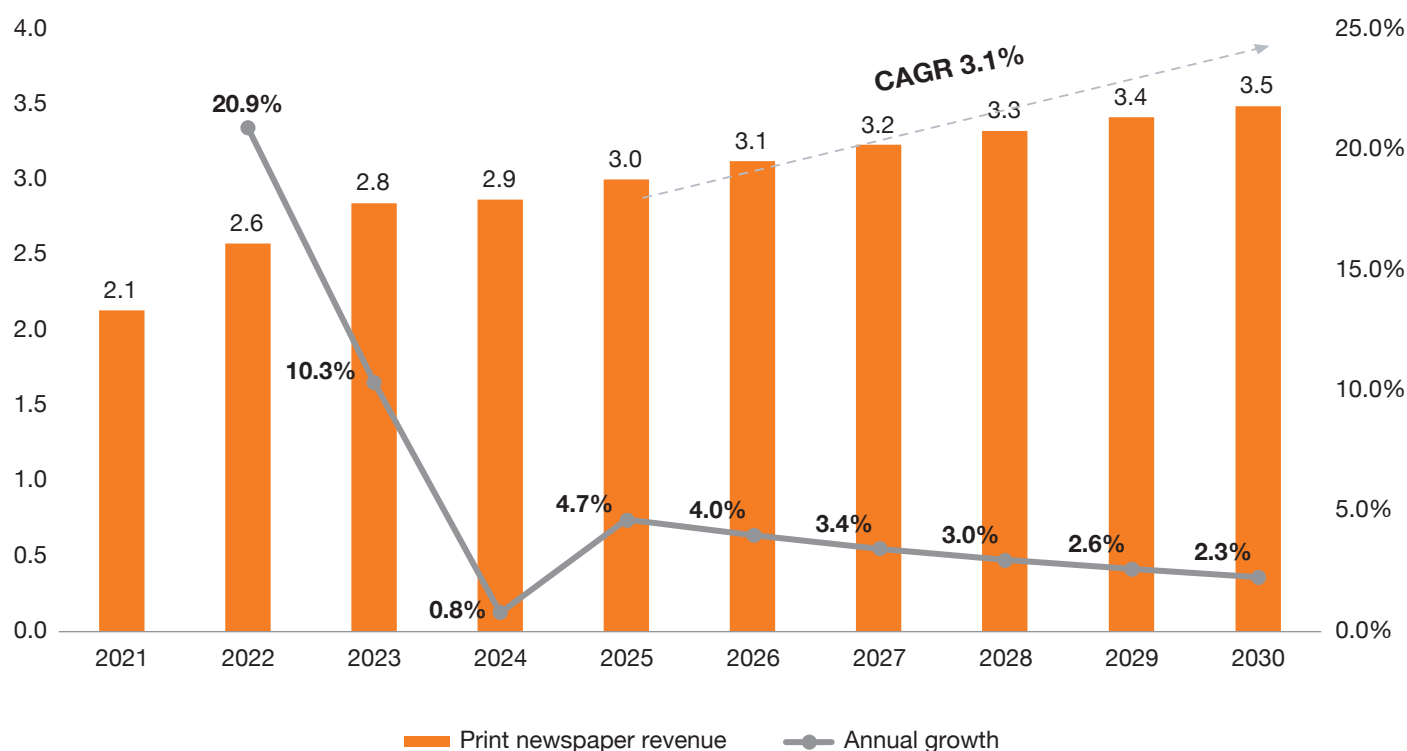
The future of television in India will be shaped by the successful integration of broadcast and streaming. The industry's next phase of growth will come from leveraging aggregation, premium content, sports rights, and regional programming across converged platforms that allow consumers to move seamlessly between traditional television and digital experiences.

India remains one of the few large media markets where newspapers continue to grow

Unlike markets in the West, where print revenues have contracted sharply, India's newspaper industry continues to benefit from strong regional readership and the enduring credibility of legacy brands. Publishers are increasingly expanding beyond traditional circulation businesses through digital subscriptions, diversified advertising products, and integrated content ecosystems.

The resilience of India's newspaper market remains one of its most distinctive characteristics. Unlike many mature Western markets where newspaper circulation and print advertising revenues have declined sharply, India remains one of the few large media markets where both continue to grow. Total newspaper revenues are projected to increase from USD3 billion in 2025 to USD3.5 billion by 2030, supported by the continued strength of print and the expansion of digital offerings.

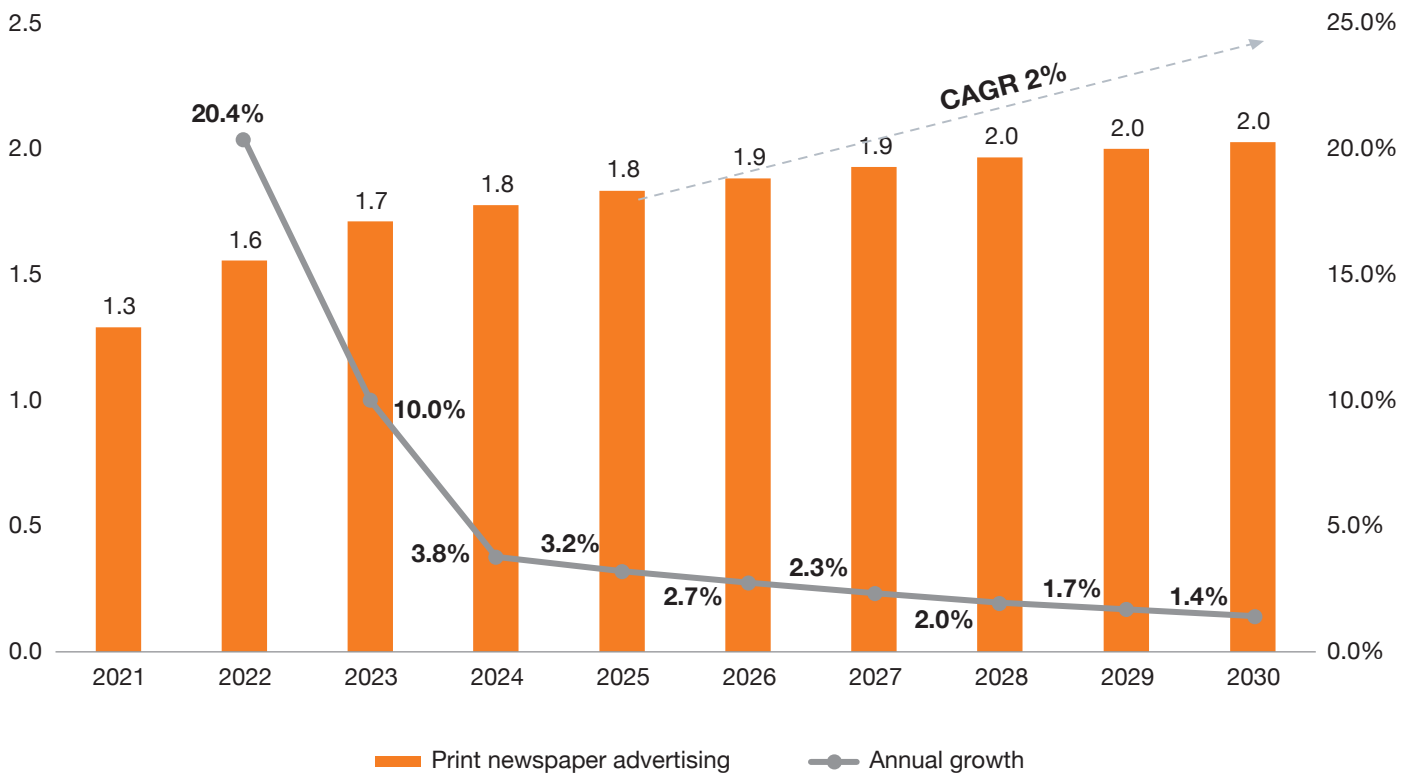
India: Newspaper revenue (in USD billion) and annual growth (%), 2021–2030



The enduring trust and credibility of established newspaper brands and strong readership in regional-language markets are the key factors behind the industry's resilience. Despite the rapid growth of digital news consumption, 39% of consumers in India continue to access news through print newspapers, a significantly higher proportion than in many global markets. This sustained readership is expected to drive print circulation revenues from USD781.9 million in 2025 to USD930.6 million by 2030.

Newspapers also remain a valuable advertising platform, offering brands a trusted and brand-safe environment with deep penetration across regional audiences. As a result, print advertising revenues are forecast to grow from USD1.8 billion in 2025 to USD2 billion by 2030.

India: Newspaper advertising revenue (in USD billion) and annual growth (%), 2021–2030



Key takeaway

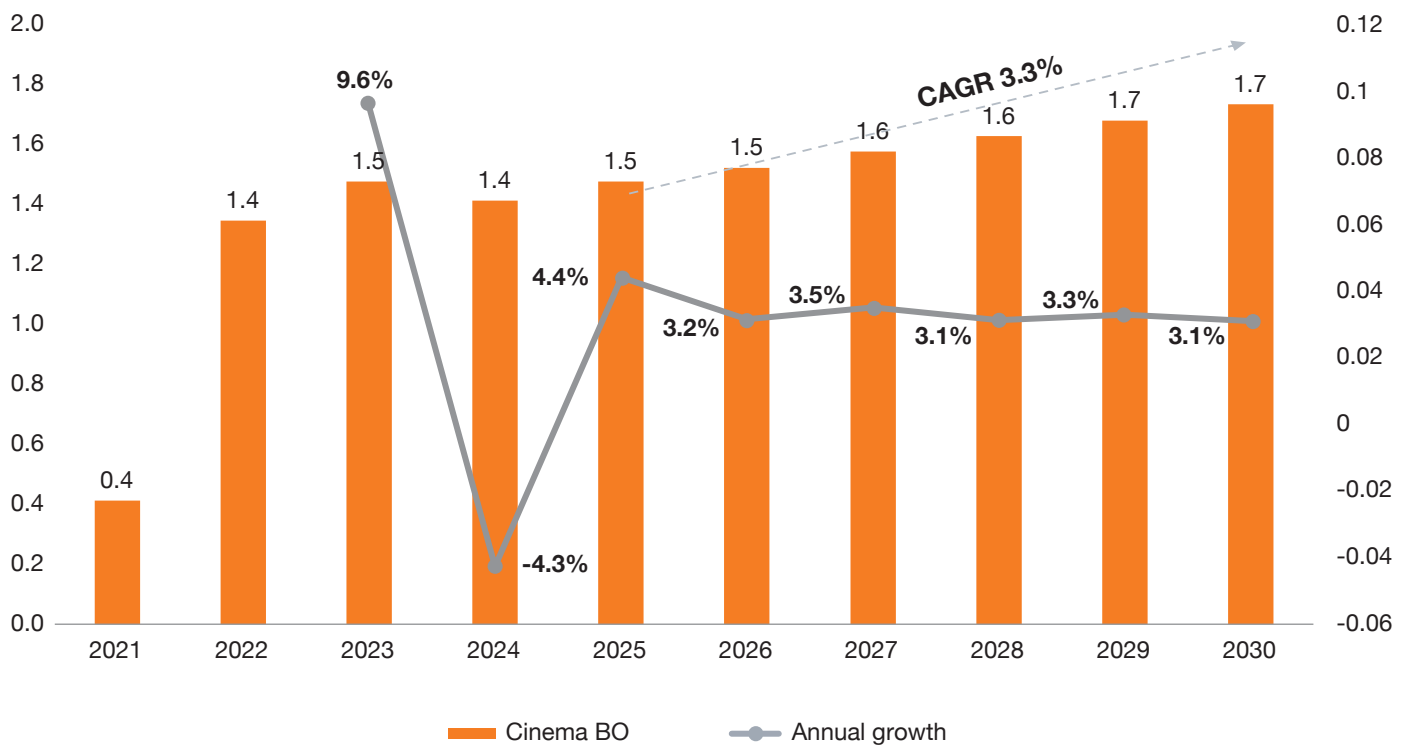
Publishers are moving beyond traditional circulation-led business models by investing in digital subscriptions, diversified advertising products, and integrated content ecosystems. Rather than replacing print, digital platforms are complementing it, enabling publishers to strengthen audience engagement, extend their reach and create additional revenue streams. The result is a uniquely Indian model in which print and digital coexist, reinforcing each other and supporting the long-term growth of the newspaper sector.

Brands are betting on high-attention, immersive cinematic experiences

Cinema is emerging as an increasingly attractive advertising platform due to the adoption of digital screens and more engaging advertising formats. As brands seek high-attention, immersive environments, cinema advertising revenues in India are forecast to grow from USD104.2 million in 2025 to USD167.8 million by 2030. Enhanced targeting capabilities, interactive campaigns, and immersive storytelling opportunities are helping cinemas capture a larger share of advertiser spending.

While box office admissions are projected to decline modestly from 832 million in 2025 to 802 million by 2030, revenues are expected to increase from USD1.5 billion to USD1.7 billion, supported by higher ticket prices, premium formats, and evolving consumer preferences. This reflects a shift from a volume-driven industry to one focused on monetising the overall cinema experience.

India: Cinema box office revenue (in USD billion) and annual growth (%), 2021–2030

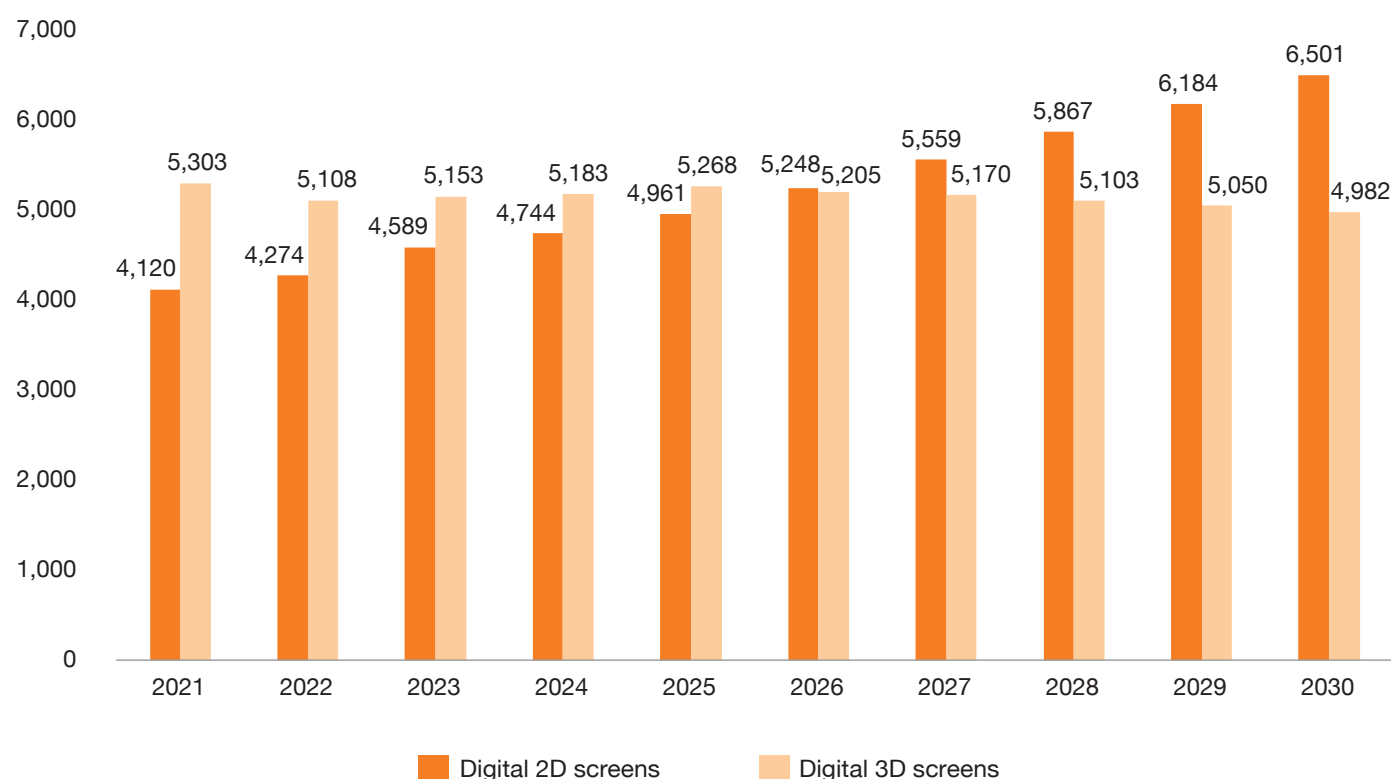


At the same time, India’s cinema infrastructure continues to grow, with more than 10,000 digital screens now operating across the country. Tier-2 and tier-3 cities are driving multiplex expansion, broadening access to theatrical entertainment beyond traditional urban centres and supporting the industry’s long-term growth potential.

Key takeaway

Premiumisation is becoming a defining feature of the sector. While 2D screens remain the dominant format, exhibitors are investing in premium large-format and 3D screens, advanced projection technology, immersive audio systems, and luxury seating to enhance the viewing experience and increase per-capita spending. These investments reflect growing consumer willingness to pay for differentiated OOH entertainment experiences that cannot be replicated through home viewing. Thus, the cinema market is evolving from one focused on footfall growth to one centred on premium experiences, advertising innovation, infrastructure expansion, and technology-enabled value creation.

India: Digital 2D and 3D screens count, 2021–2030



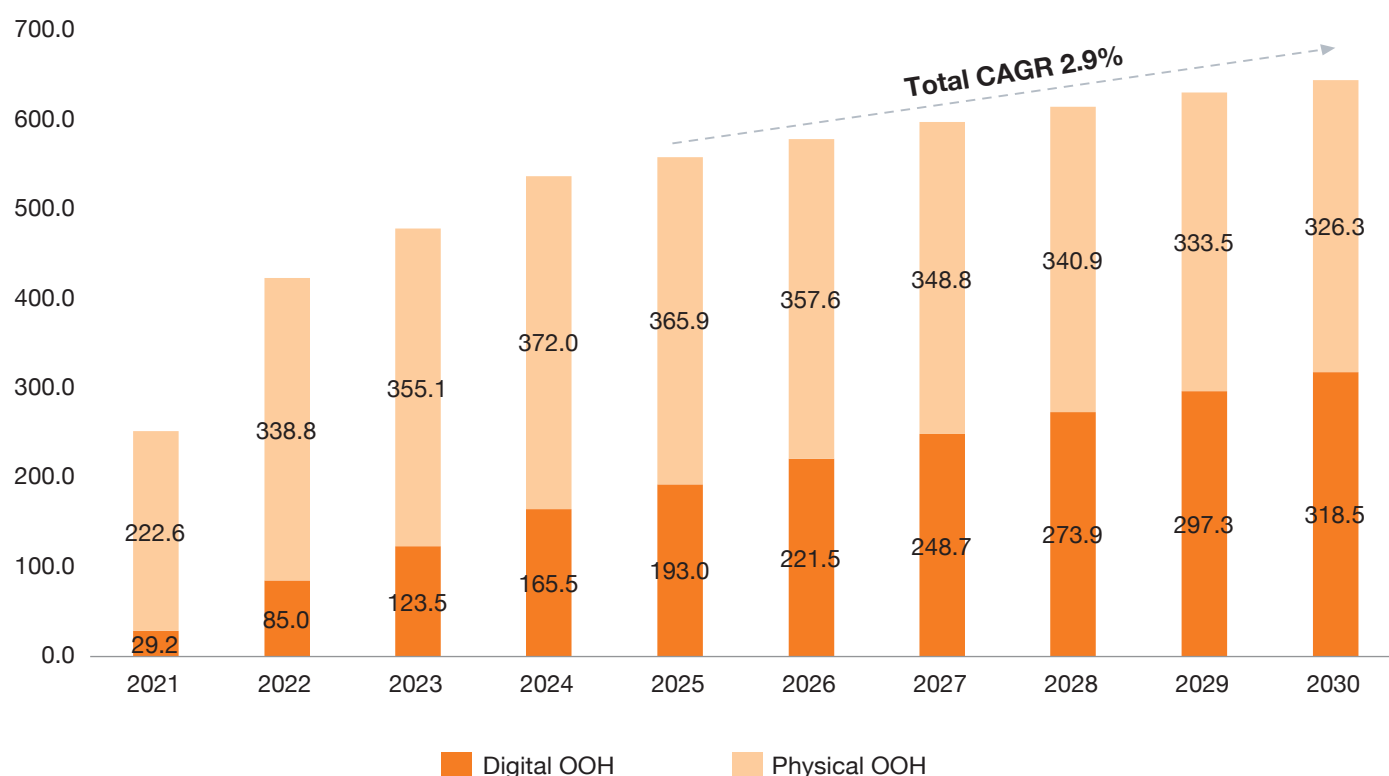
Data and digital are reshaping OOH advertising

India's OOH advertising market is rapidly evolving into a digital and data-driven ecosystem, supported by strong economic growth, accelerating urbanisation, and significant investments in transport infrastructure. The market is expected to reach USD558.9 million in 2025 and grow at a 2.9% CAGR through 2030, making India one of the fastest-growing OOH markets in the region.

A major catalyst for this transformation is the expansion of India's transit infrastructure. Large-scale investments in metro rail systems, highways, and airports are creating high-dwell-time environments that are ideal for digital advertising. The rapid expansion of metro networks across cities such as Delhi, Mumbai, Bengaluru, Chennai, and Kolkata, alongside new systems being developed in

emerging urban centres, is significantly increasing the premium digital advertising inventory. These transit hubs are becoming the focal point of the industry's next phase of growth, providing advertisers with access to large, mobile, and increasingly affluent audiences.

This infrastructure-led expansion is accelerating the shift from traditional outdoor advertising to digital OOH (DOOH). The market is undergoing active digitisation, with media owners investing heavily in high-impact digital installations across airports, railway stations, metro networks, and roadside locations. As a result, DOOH is expected to account for more than 34.5% of total OOH advertising expenditure in 2025, highlighting the increasing preference for dynamic, flexible, and data-enabled advertising formats.

India: OOH revenue (in USD million), 2021–2030

Programmatic buying is emerging as another key growth driver. In 2025, the launch of programmatic DOOH capabilities at Bengaluru's Kempegowda International Airport provided advertisers with automated access to 64 digital screens generating more than 41 million monthly impressions. This enables brands to target high-value audience segments, such as business travellers, with greater precision, flexibility, and campaign optimisation. The introduction of programmatic trading models is helping align DOOH more closely with broader digital advertising ecosystems and improving the medium's attractiveness to advertisers seeking measurable and targeted media investments.

The industry is also witnessing continued investment in next-generation digital networks and data-driven advertising solutions. New digital bus shelter networks, large-format video walls, and AI-enabled content creation platforms are expanding the capabilities of the medium. These innovations allow advertisers to deliver dynamic content, real-time messaging, and integrated omnichannel campaigns that combine OOH, DOOH, and digital marketing.

Key takeaway

India's OOH sector is well positioned to benefit from continued urbanisation, infrastructure development, and the rising spending power of a large Gen Z consumer base. As digital inventory expands across transit hubs, airports, and metro networks, and programmatic trading becomes more widespread, the market is expected to unlock new revenue pools and evolve into a more sophisticated, technology-driven advertising ecosystem. The industry's ability to deliver measurable, data-led, and highly targeted advertising experiences will drive its next stage of growth.





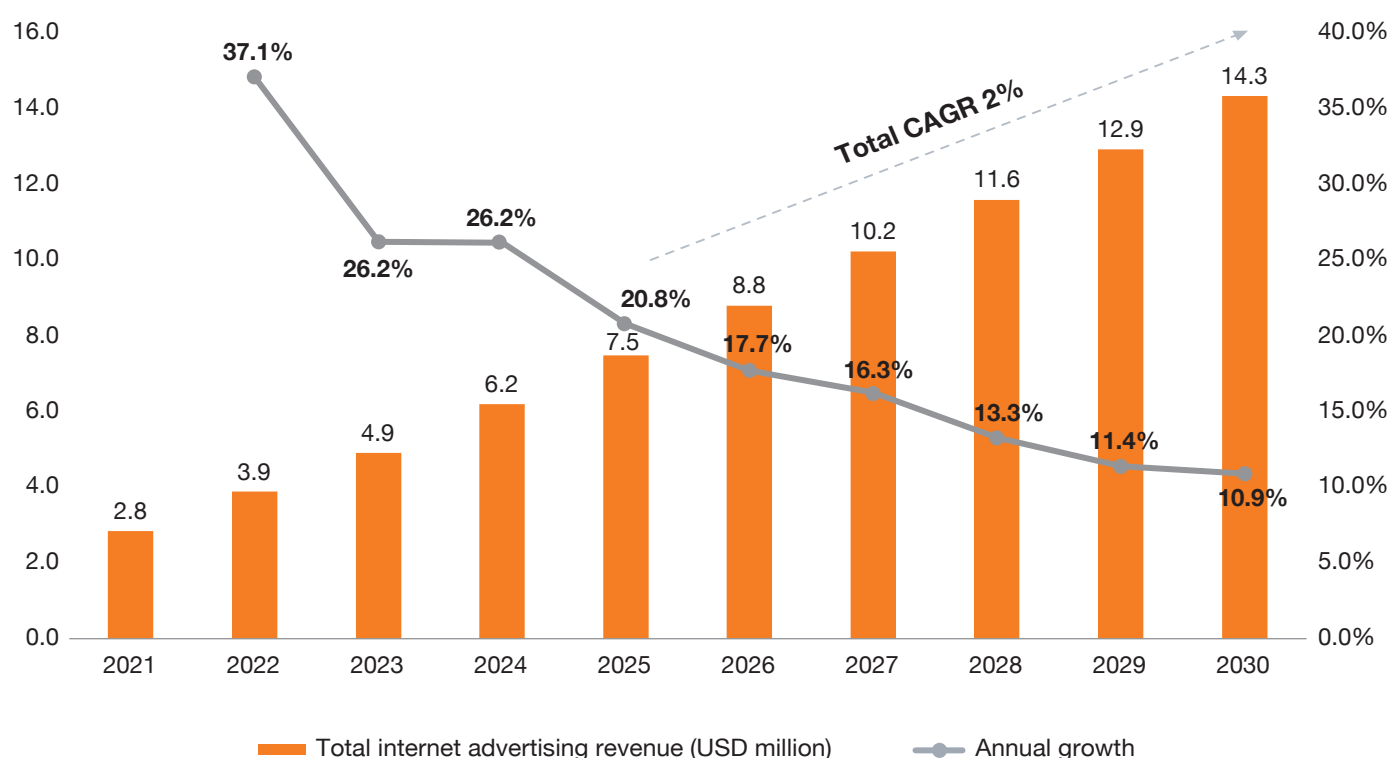
3.2 Digital media

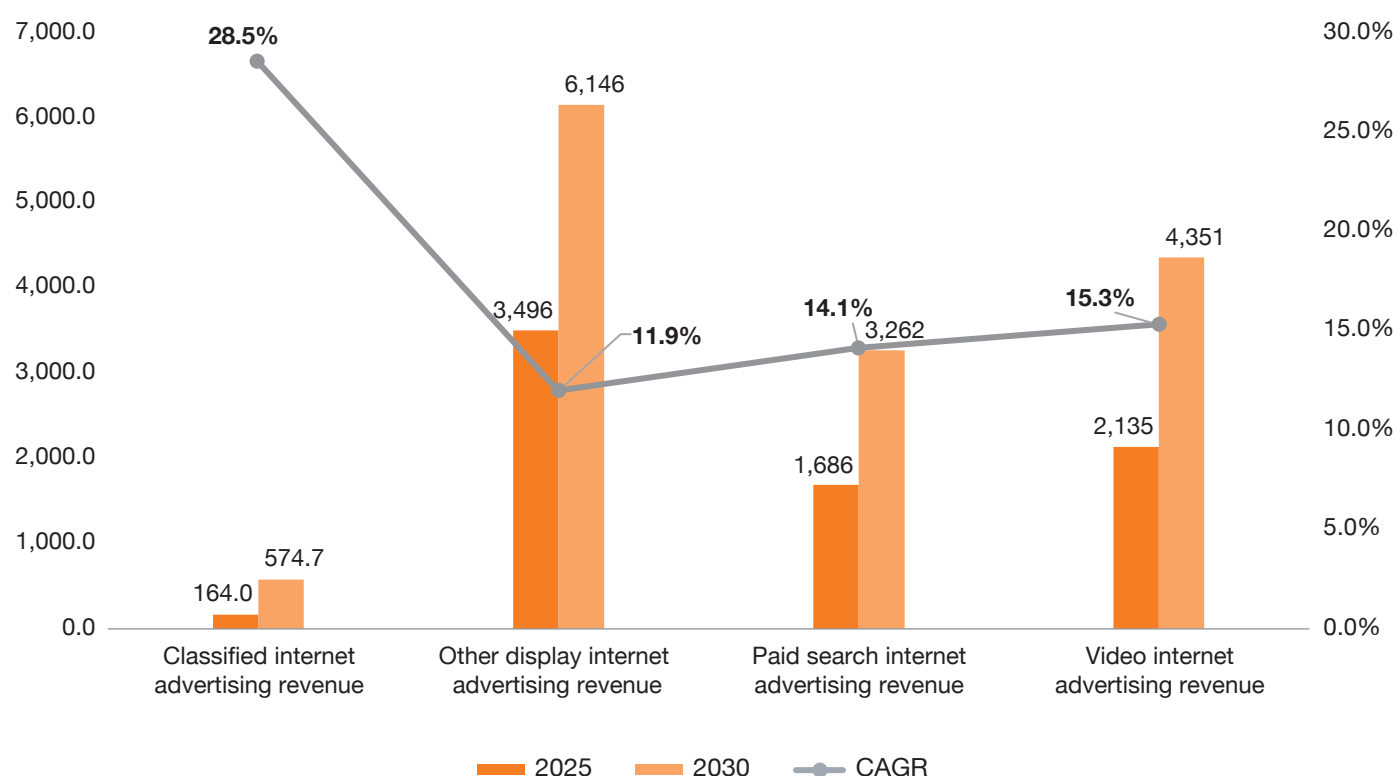
While audience acquisition defined the first decade of India's digital revolution, audience monetisation will define the next one. Accordingly, the focus of businesses is shifting from user acquisition to improving revenue generation, deepening engagement, and creating sustainable economics.

Internet advertising is the primary growth engine of India's E&M sector

Internet advertising has firmly established itself as the primary growth engine of India's E&M sector. Total internet advertising revenues reached USD7.5 billion in 2025 and are forecast to almost double to USD14.3 billion by 2030, growing at a robust 13.9% CAGR.

India: Internet advertising revenue (in USD billion) and annual growth (%), 2021–2030



India: Internet advertising revenue (in USD billion) and annual growth (%), 2021–2030

Strong performance across both search and display advertising is driving growth. Paid search advertising is expected to grow at a 14.1% CAGR through 2030, while display advertising is projected to expand at a 13.3% CAGR. Within display, video advertising is the fastest-growing category, increasing at a 15.3% CAGR. This reflects advertisers' increasing preference for rich, engaging, and mobile-friendly formats. In 2025, other display advertising remained the largest category, accounting for 46.7% of total internet advertising revenues, followed by video advertising (28.5%), paid search (22.5%), and classified advertising (2.2%).

India's status as a mobile-first market is the main factor behind digital advertising growth. Smartphone penetration has reached unprecedented levels, with 91% of urban households and 82.1% of rural households having access to at least one smartphone. By contrast, fixed broadband penetration remains relatively limited, making mobile devices the primary gateway for digital content consumption and advertising exposure. This has created an environment where search, social media, short-form video, and mobile video advertising collectively command increasing advertiser attention and spending.

Large digital ecosystems such as Google, YouTube, Facebook, Instagram, and WhatsApp dominate the market, attracting the majority of digital advertising investments. At the same time, the creator economy is emerging as a powerful advertising channel, with influencers playing an increasingly important role in connecting brands with consumers.

Short-form video continues to be one of the most significant growth drivers within the digital advertising ecosystem. Platforms such as Instagram Reels, YouTube Shorts, and local players such as Moj and ShareChat have captured large audiences across the country. Instagram alone had more than 390 million users in India in 2025, making it the platform's largest market globally. Notably, usage of these platforms is increasingly concentrated in tier-2 and tier-3 cities, and rural markets, expanding advertisers' ability to reach consumers beyond major metropolitan centres.

Another important development is the emergence of telecom-led advertising ecosystems. Reliance Jio has leveraged its extensive consumer footprint to build a substantial advertising business, with access to an addressable audience of more than 400 million customers and reach across approximately half of India's internet-connected homes. Its advertising offerings span retail media, programmatic advertising, connected TV, and mobile advertising, highlighting the growing convergence of connectivity, content, and commerce within India's digital economy.

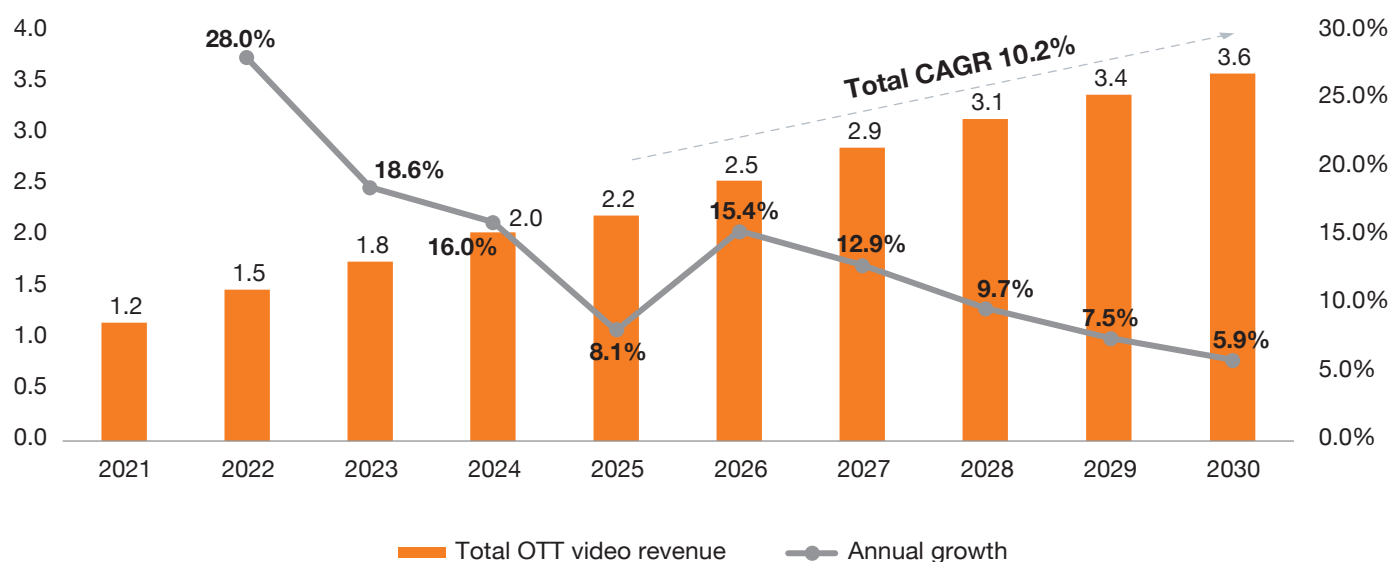
Key takeaway

Internet advertising is expected to benefit from continued growth in smartphone adoption, rising video consumption, the expansion of India's creator economy, and the increasing sophistication of retail media and programmatic advertising. As advertisers seek greater precision, scale, and measurable outcomes, digital channels are likely to capture an increasing share of marketing budgets, strengthening internet advertising's position as the industry's primary growth engine.

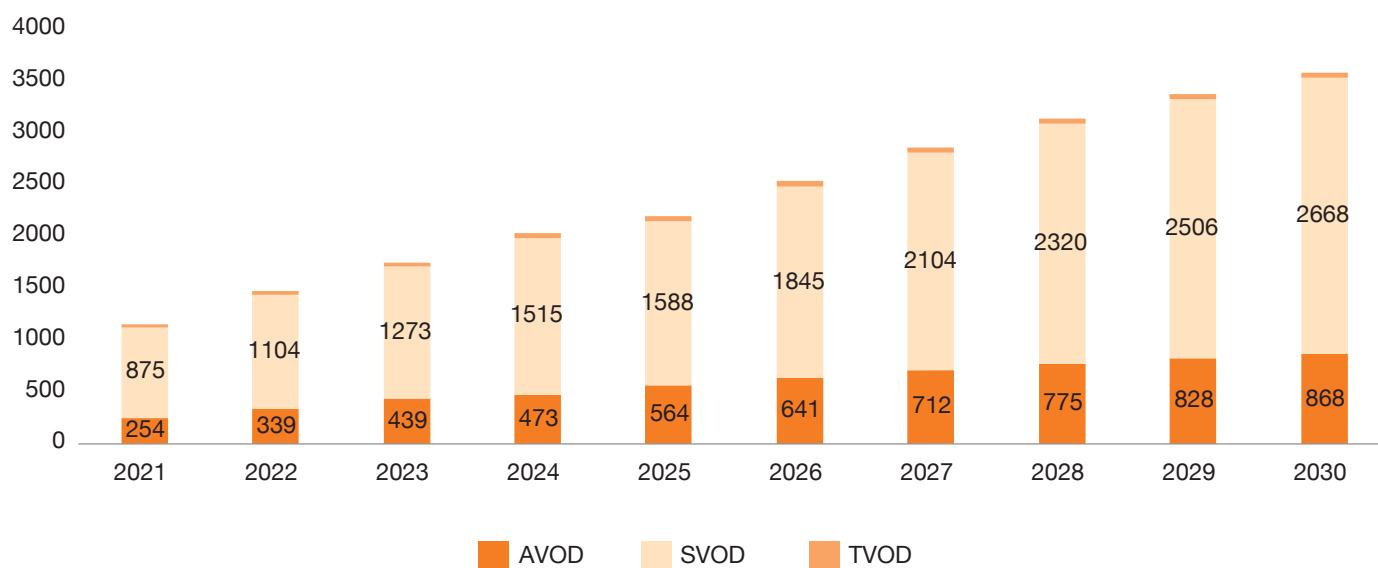
OTT market grows through scale while monetisation upside

India's OTT market generated USD2.2 billion in revenue in 2025 and is projected to reach USD3.6 billion by 2030, supported by a subscriber base of 216.5 million, the third-largest globally. However, despite this scale, the market continues to operate with a relatively low average revenue per user (ARPU) of USD7.3, reflecting the price-sensitive nature of Indian consumers and creating a significant opportunity for monetisation-led growth.

India: OTT revenue (in USD billion) and annual growth (%), 2021–2030



India: OTT revenue by component (in USD million)



The OTT market illustrates the shift from scale to monetisation. While subscriber growth remains healthy, major platforms are increasingly focused on:

- **Advertising-supported offerings**

Advertising has become a critical component of OTT business models as platforms seek to monetise large audiences while maintaining affordability. Ad-supported video-on-demand (AVoD) offerings are now widely adopted by leading services such as JioHotstar, Amazon Prime Video, and ZEE5. Streaming advertising revenues reached USD563.9 million in 2025 and continue to be an important source of incremental revenue in a market where consumers remain highly price conscious. Amazon Prime Video's introduction of advertising-supported viewing in India in 2025 underscored the growing importance of advertising. It allowed the platform to generate additional revenue while keeping entry prices accessible for consumers.

- **Subscriber retention and ARPU expansion**

As subscriber acquisition becomes more challenging, OTT platforms are increasingly focusing on improving engagement and extracting greater value from existing users. Subscription revenue remains the largest component of the market, contributing USD1.6 billion in 2025 and projected to grow to USD2.7 billion by 2030. To support this growth, platforms are investing heavily in premium content, exclusive entertainment franchises, regional programming, and sports rights that help drive engagement and reduce churn. The objective is to deepen customer relationships and improve

monetisation rather than simply add subscribers.

Local content remains central to this strategy. Leading players such as JioHotstar, Amazon Prime Video, Sun NXT and Eros Now accounted for nearly 60% of streaming subscribers in 2025, with strong libraries of Bollywood, regional-language content, and live cricket helping to maintain viewer loyalty. JioHotstar's reported growth from 50 million to 100 million subscribers in 2025 demonstrates the continued ability of premium sports and entertainment content to attract and retain audiences at scale.

- **Content aggregation**

Content aggregation and industry consolidation are emerging as defining trends in the next phase of market development. The creation of JioHotstar, following the merger of Reliance and Disney's streaming operations, reflects a broader move towards larger content ecosystems capable of serving multiple consumer needs through a single platform. By combining premium sports rights, international programming, Bollywood content, and regional entertainment, aggregated platforms are seeking to improve user engagement, increase consumption, and strengthen monetisation opportunities. Larger content libraries also support higher investment in premium programming and sports rights, helping platforms differentiate themselves in an increasingly competitive market.



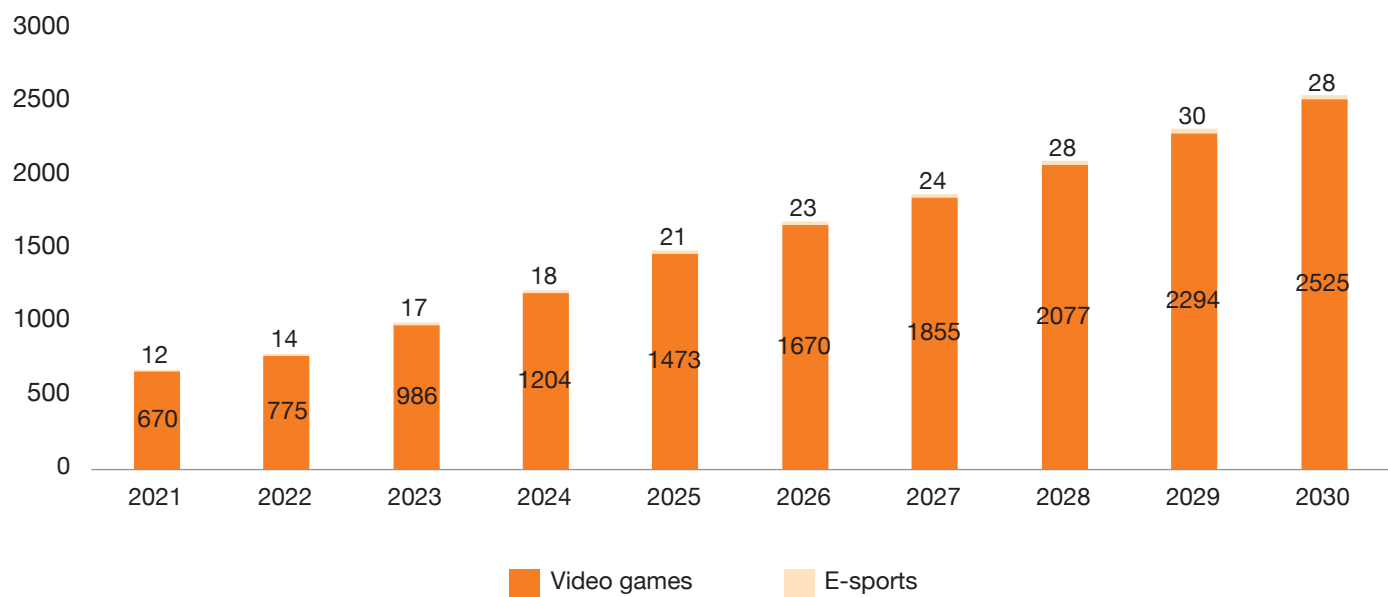
Key takeaway

The OTT sector is moving beyond a growth model centred purely on subscriber addition. The next phase will be defined by how effectively platforms leverage advertising, strengthen subscriber loyalty, improve revenue per user, and build comprehensive content ecosystems capable of converting scale into sustainable long-term value.

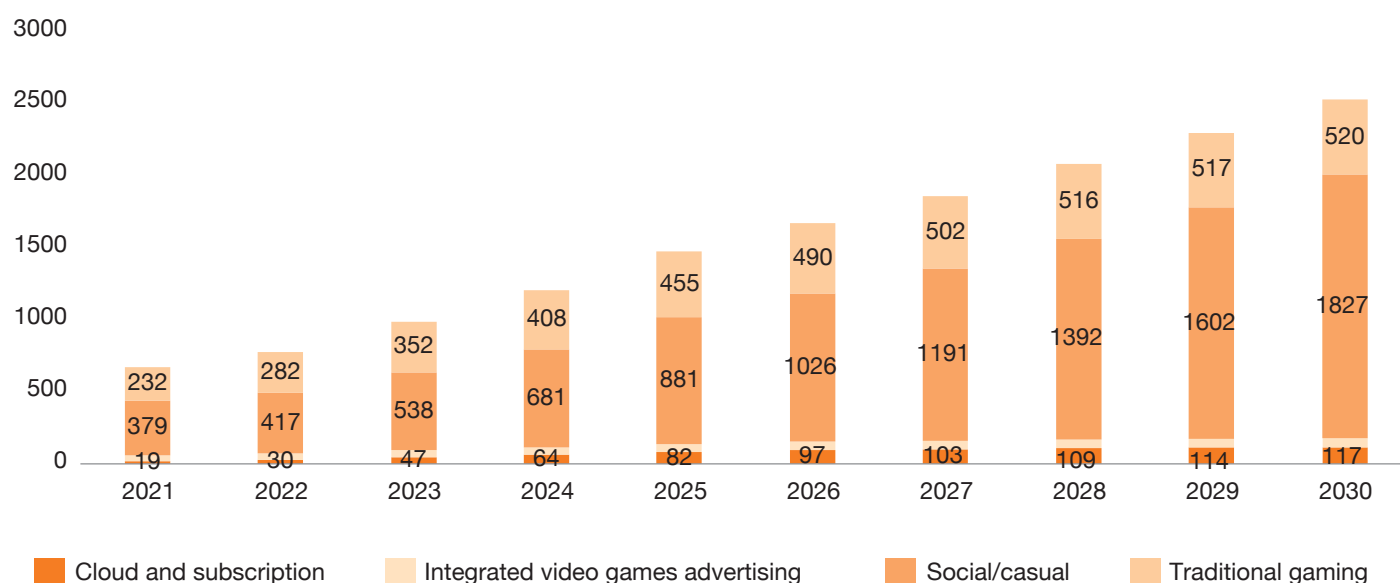
Monetisation improvements will strengthen India’s global gaming position

Gaming is one of India’s fastest-growing digital media segments. The market is projected to grow from USD1.5 billion in 2025 to USD2.6 billion by 2030, representing a strong 11.3% CAGR. While India remains a relatively small contributor to global gaming revenues, rising gaming penetration and gradual improvements in monetisation are expected to strengthen its position over the forecast period.

India: Video games and e-sports revenue (in USD million), 2021–2030





India: Video games revenue, split by component (in USD million), 2021-2030

While mobile users continue to drive the industry, monetisation increasingly depends on:

- **In-game advertising**

The scale of India's mobile gaming audience offers significant opportunities for brands to engage consumers through in-game placements and mobile advertising formats. This trend is reflected in the strong growth of the social and casual gaming segment, which generated USD881.4 million in 2025 and is forecast to reach USD1.8 billion by 2030, making it the largest component of the gaming ecosystem (see figure above).

- **Sponsorships and e-sports**

E-sports is emerging as a growing opportunity within the broader gaming landscape, with the market expected to expand at a 5.8% CAGR through 2030. The Indian e-sports ecosystem is primarily centred on mobile gaming and is increasingly attracting brand interest as competitive gaming audiences expand. Future revenue growth is expected to be driven largely by team sponsorships, tournament sponsorships, and advertising associated with e-sports content and tournament streaming, creating new monetisation opportunities beyond traditional game purchases.

- **Subscription offerings**

As the market matures, subscription-based and recurring revenue models are expected to play a larger role in improving monetisation. India's gaming audience has historically gravitated towards free-to-play experiences, but increasing digital adoption and a growing base of engaged gamers are creating opportunities for premium content and subscription services. Traditional gaming, including console and PC gaming, generated USD455 million in 2025 and is forecast to grow to USD520.3 million by 2030, supported by continued demand for premium gaming experiences (see figure above).

Key takeaway

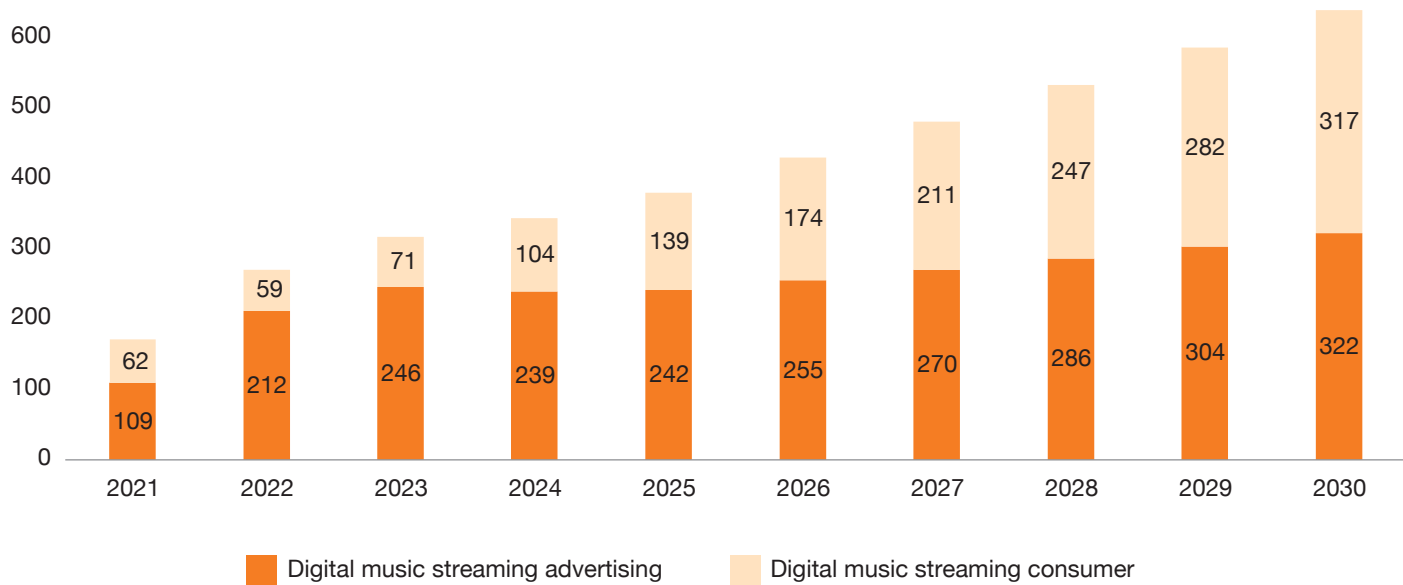
The Indian gaming industry is moving beyond pure audience growth towards a more diversified revenue model. While mobile gaming remains the dominant access point, future value creation will increasingly be driven by advertising, sponsorship-led e-sports ecosystems, and recurring revenue streams that improve monetisation across a rapidly expanding user base.

Digital audio market is moving towards subscription-led models

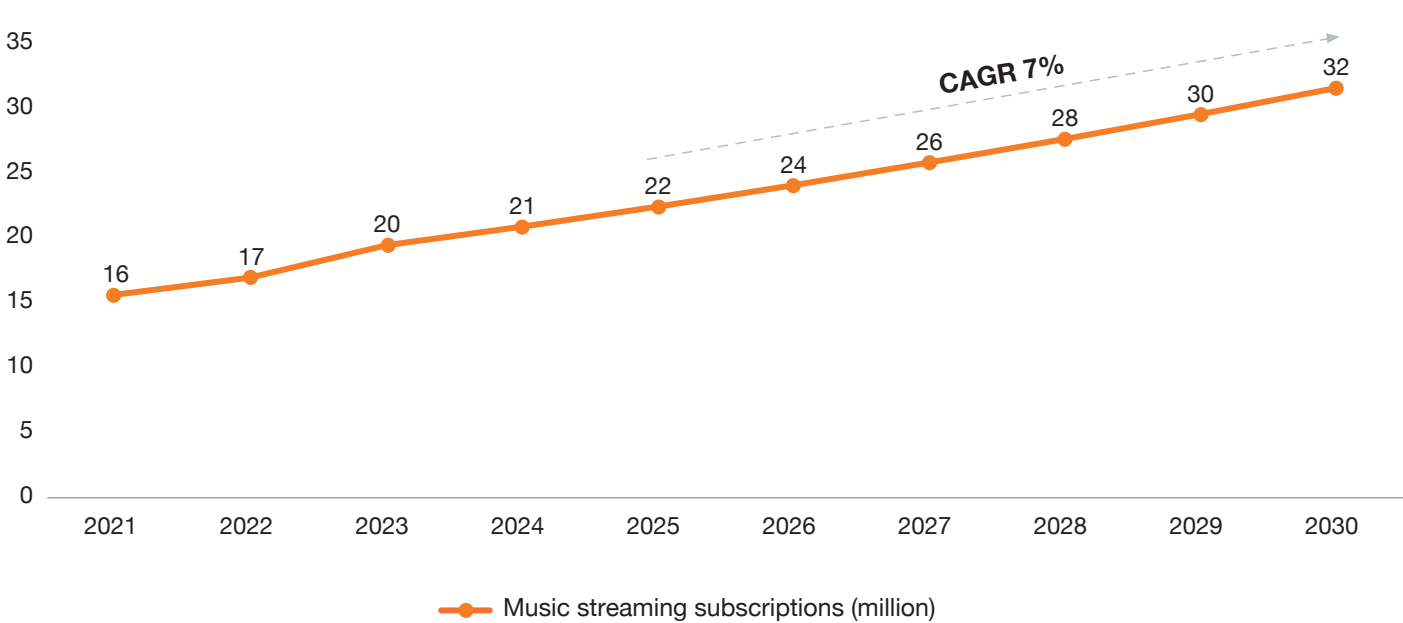
India’s digital audio market is entering a more mature phase of development, evolving from a predominantly ad-supported ecosystem towards subscription-led growth. The broader audio entertainment market, encompassing music streaming, radio, and podcasts, generated USD807.2 million in revenue in 2025 and is projected to reach USD1.1 billion by 2030, growing at a 6.8% CAGR.

The music streaming market is growing strongly, and while it started as an ad-driven (free) market, consumer/ subscription revenue is catching up fast (see figure below).

India: Music streaming revenue by component (in USD million), 2021–2030



India: Music streaming subscriptions (in million), 2021–2030



A key driver of this evolution is the industry's increasing focus on converting large digital audiences into paying subscribers and improving monetisation in a market that has historically been characterised by low ARPUs and freemium consumption models.

Music streaming remains the fastest-growing segment within the audio ecosystem, generating USD381 million in revenue in 2025 and forecast to grow at an 11.0% CAGR through 2030. The market is undergoing a structural transition as streaming platforms increasingly prioritise paid subscriptions over free access. This shift was highlighted by Gaana's move behind a full paywall following its consolidation with Entertainment Network India Limited (ENIL), alongside a doubling of subscription pricing. Industry leaders are increasingly advocating for a broader market transition towards paid services as platforms seek sustainable monetisation models. Despite this shift, competition remains intense. JioSaavn, Spotify, and YouTube continue to offer ad-supported services while also introducing aggressive pricing and premium plans to encourage subscriber conversion.

Podcasting is also emerging as a significant component of the digital audio landscape. Driven by smartphone penetration, affordable data, and a growing audience for on-demand content, podcasts have reached an estimated 199 million monthly listeners in India. Increasing adoption by creators, brands, corporations, and public institutions is helping establish podcasts as a mainstream content format and an increasingly important revenue opportunity within the wider audio ecosystem.

Key takeaway

The digital audio sector is moving beyond audience acquisition towards a more sustainable monetisation model, with subscription-led growth, expanding podcast consumption, and regional language content emerging as the key drivers of future value creation.



04

Regionalisation is a powerful growth engine

The rise of the regional is redefining cinema, streaming, and music. Whether it is regional cinema rivalling Bollywood at the box office, regional-language content driving OTT subscriptions, or local-language tracks fuelling music streaming, regionalisation has become a powerful force shaping growth across the sector.

A. Cinema

One of the most significant shifts reshaping the cinema market is the rise of regional cinema as a national commercial force. While Hindi films continue to account for the largest single-language share of box office revenues, the combined strength of the Tamil, Telugu, Malayalam, and Kannada industries now exceeds that of any individual language market, reflecting a more diversified and competitive cinema ecosystem.

Regional films are increasingly transcending linguistic boundaries through dubbed, subtitled, and multilingual releases, enabling locally rooted stories to reach audiences across the country. This has fuelled the rise of ‘pan-India’ cinema, where films originally produced for regional audiences are distributed nationally and compete directly with traditional Bollywood releases. High-profile titles such as *Kantara: A Legend Chapter 1*, *Coolie*, and *Pushpa 2* have demonstrated the growing commercial appeal of regional content by frequently outperforming comparable Hindi-language productions at the box office.

The success of Telugu, Tamil, and Kannada cinema reflects a broader structural rebalancing of India’s film landscape. Commercial success is no longer concentrated within Mumbai’s Bollywood ecosystem; instead, creative and economic influence is increasingly dispersed across multiple regional production centres. Wider distribution strategies, combined with growing audience acceptance of dubbed and subtitled content, have enabled non-Hindi films to reach national audiences at an unprecedented scale.

This trend is expected to strengthen further as studios increasingly develop large-scale multilingual productions designed for nationwide release from day one. Upcoming films such as *Ramayana* and *Varanasi* are positioned as pan-India event films aimed at attracting audiences across regional and national markets simultaneously.

Importantly, the rise of regional cinema does not signal the decline of Bollywood as Hindi-language films remain some of the country’s biggest commercial successes. What this means is that India’s cinema market is no longer dominated by a single industry and is evolving into a multi-centre ecosystem where regional and Hindi-language content coexist, compete, and increasingly complement one another.

B. OTT

Regional storytelling has emerged as one of the most powerful subscriber acquisition tools in India's OTT market. As streaming platforms compete for audiences in a highly price-sensitive environment, investment in local language content has become a key differentiator. Leading platforms such as JioHotstar, Sun NXT, and Amazon Prime Video have built large subscriber bases by offering a mix of Bollywood content, regional-language programming, and local originals that resonate with diverse audiences across the country.

While India's OTT market has grown to 216.5 million subscriptions in 2025, platforms are increasingly looking beyond Hindi-speaking audiences to drive future growth. Regional platforms such as Sun NXT, which focuses on Tamil, Telugu, and Kannada content, demonstrate the strong demand for local-language entertainment and the role it plays in attracting and retaining subscribers.

For both domestic and global streaming players, local content has become essential to competing in India. The ability to combine national content, sports rights, and regional programming within a single platform is driving the success of market leaders. On the other hand, global players such as Amazon Prime Video have continued investing heavily in local movies and original series to accelerate subscriber growth.

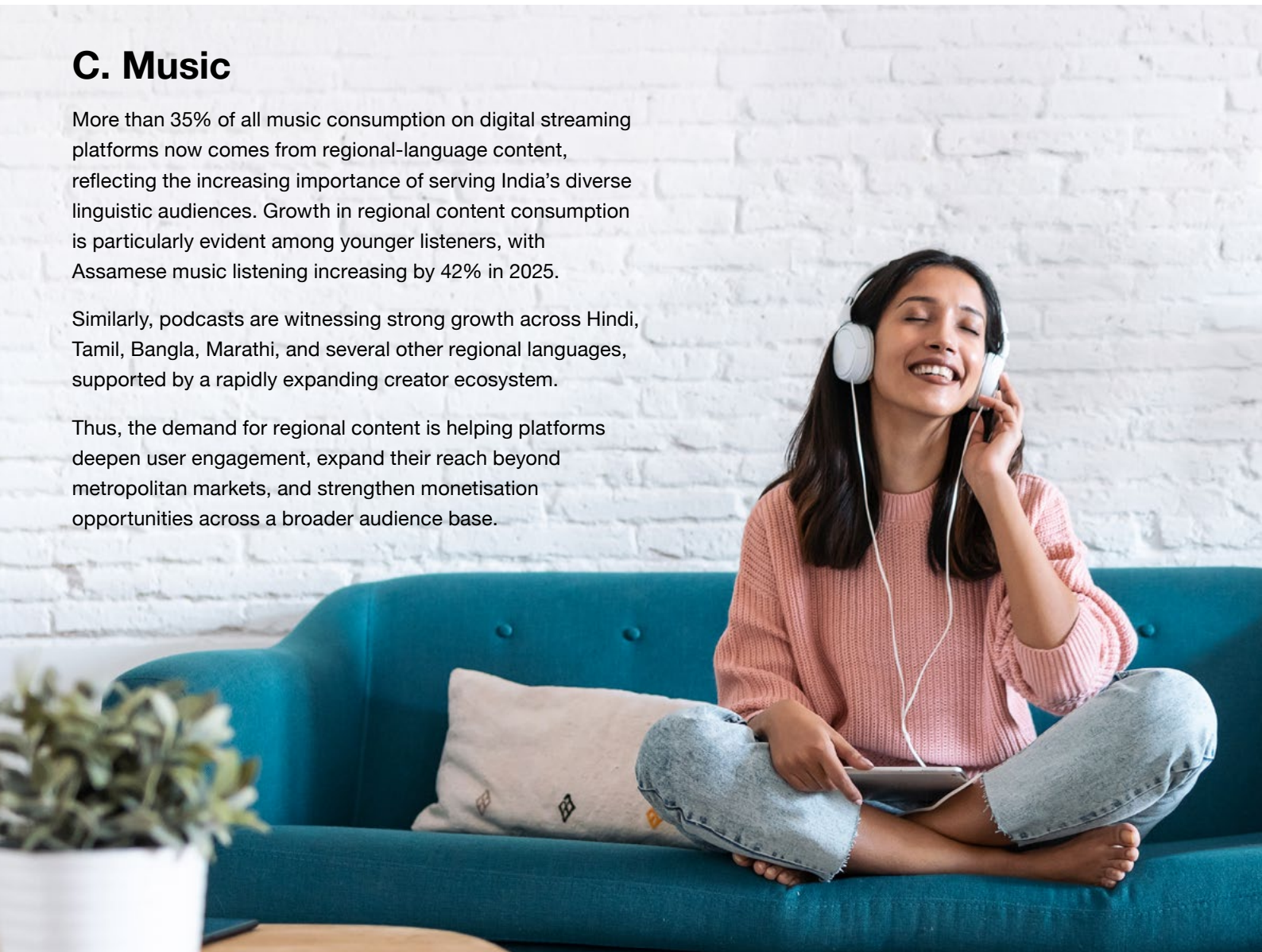
Local language storytelling is expected to remain a key growth driver, helping platforms expand their reach across India's diverse linguistic markets and deepen engagement with audiences beyond the major metropolitan centres.

C. Music

More than 35% of all music consumption on digital streaming platforms now comes from regional-language content, reflecting the increasing importance of serving India's diverse linguistic audiences. Growth in regional content consumption is particularly evident among younger listeners, with Assamese music listening increasing by 42% in 2025.

Similarly, podcasts are witnessing strong growth across Hindi, Tamil, Bangla, Marathi, and several other regional languages, supported by a rapidly expanding creator ecosystem.

Thus, the demand for regional content is helping platforms deepen user engagement, expand their reach beyond metropolitan markets, and strengthen monetisation opportunities across a broader audience base.



05

Future in motion: Connectivity, live experiences, and AI

The future of India's E&M industry will be powered by three converging forces: connectivity, AI, and live experiences. Together, they are set to redefine how content is created, distributed, and consumed across the country.

**Connectivity**

Expanding digital and physical infrastructure are bringing new audiences and formats online.

**Live experiences**

Live experiences are driving high-engagement, immersive moments that deepen audience connection.

**AI**

AI is set to change how content is produced, personalised, and monetised.

5.1 Connectivity is becoming a critical enabler for the industry

Infrastructure investment is increasingly becoming media investment. As India expands its digital connectivity backbone through mobile networks, broadband, and fibre infrastructure it is laying the foundations for the next phase of media consumption, digital advertising, and audience engagement. The country's rapidly growing smartphone ecosystem and expanding digital reach are enabling new content formats, advertising models, and media platforms to scale across urban and rural markets alike. In effect, connectivity infrastructure is enabling entirely new media ecosystems to take shape.

The country remains a mobile-first market, with approximately 1 billion fixed and mobile subscriptions and smartphone access available to 91% of urban households and 82.1% of rural households. This widespread connectivity has transformed mobile devices into the primary gateway for content consumption, digital services, and advertising, creating new opportunities for media companies, advertisers, and content creators to reach audiences at an unprecedented scale.

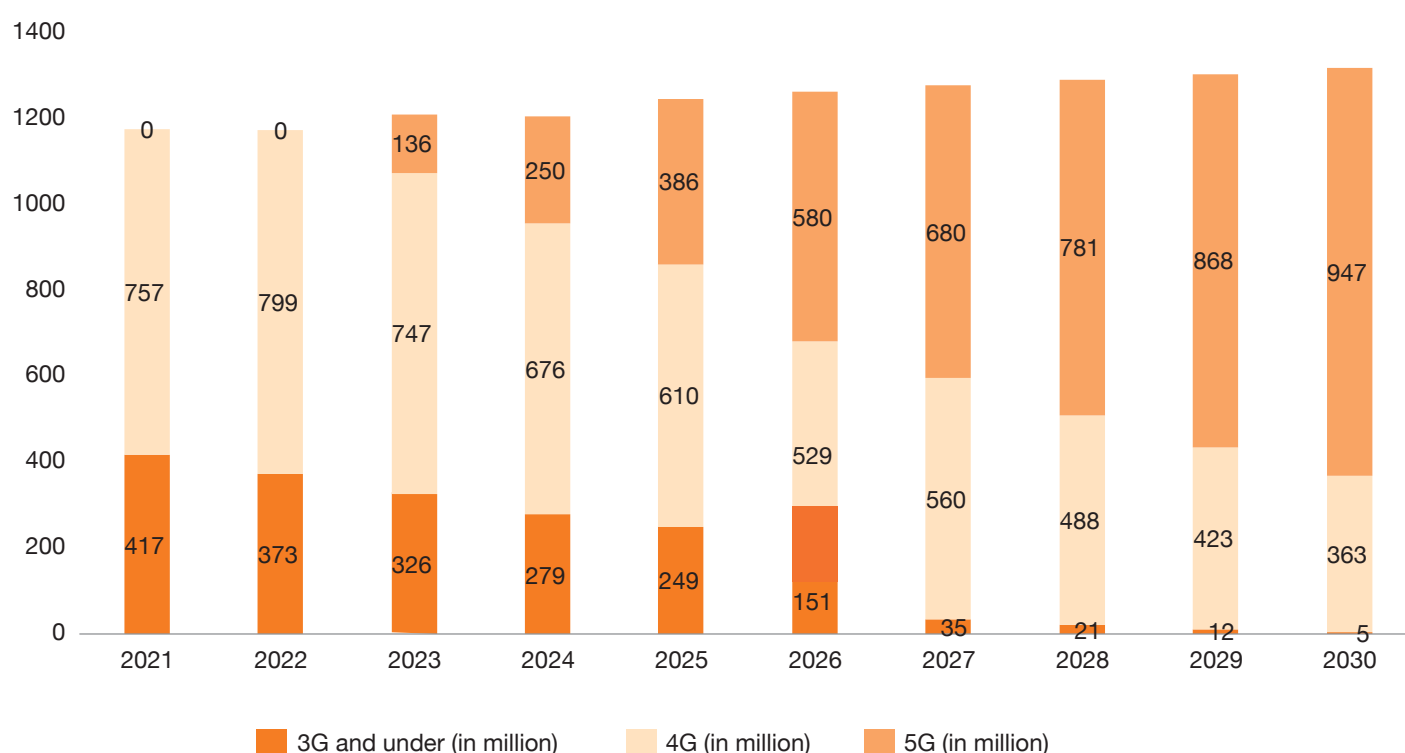
The rapid expansion of mobile connectivity is accelerating the consumption of digital media, particularly video. Video formats are driving internet advertising growth, with video advertising expected to grow at 15.3% CAGR, the fastest-growing category in the market. Broadband and high-speed mobile networks are enabling richer content experiences and supporting the growth of video-led platforms across streaming, short-form content, and social media.

India's mobile-first nature is also shaping where advertisers deploy budgets. Search and display advertising, particularly video advertising, are benefiting from growing smartphone penetration and increasing consumer engagement across digital platforms.



Growth in 5G connections (2021–2030)

India: 3G, 4G, and 5G subscriptions (in million), 2021–2030



As audiences become more mobile and connected, transit hubs are evolving into valuable media touchpoints. The combination of digital connectivity, smartphone penetration, and location-based advertising is creating opportunities for more targeted and contextually relevant consumer engagement. Advertisers are seeking ways to connect with audiences across multiple digital and physical touchpoints, reinforcing the role of transport infrastructure as an extension of the broader media ecosystem.

Improved infrastructure is also supporting the growth of business ecosystems and commercial engagement. The boost in connectivity and digital access is enabling companies to reach customers more effectively, while creating larger addressable markets for advertising and media services. Companies are increasingly leveraging

their distribution and consumer networks as advertising platforms in their own right. For example, Reliance Jio has built an advertising ecosystem reaching more than 400 million customers, 267 million registered users, and approximately half of India's internet-connected homes, spanning retail media, programmatic advertising, mobile advertising, and connected TV.

The result is an increasingly interconnected ecosystem where physical infrastructure, digital connectivity, and media platforms reinforce one another. As broadband, mobile networks, digital advertising capabilities, and consumer connectivity continue to expand, infrastructure is becoming a critical enabler of future media growth and value creation.

5.2 Unlocking new value pools through premium experiences

Across sports, music, and cinema, consumers are demonstrating a growing willingness to pay for immersion, exclusivity, and premium access. This trend is creating some of the most attractive new growth opportunities across the industry. This shift is particularly evident in the live music sector, where audiences are moving beyond basic event attendance and seeking higher-value experiences.

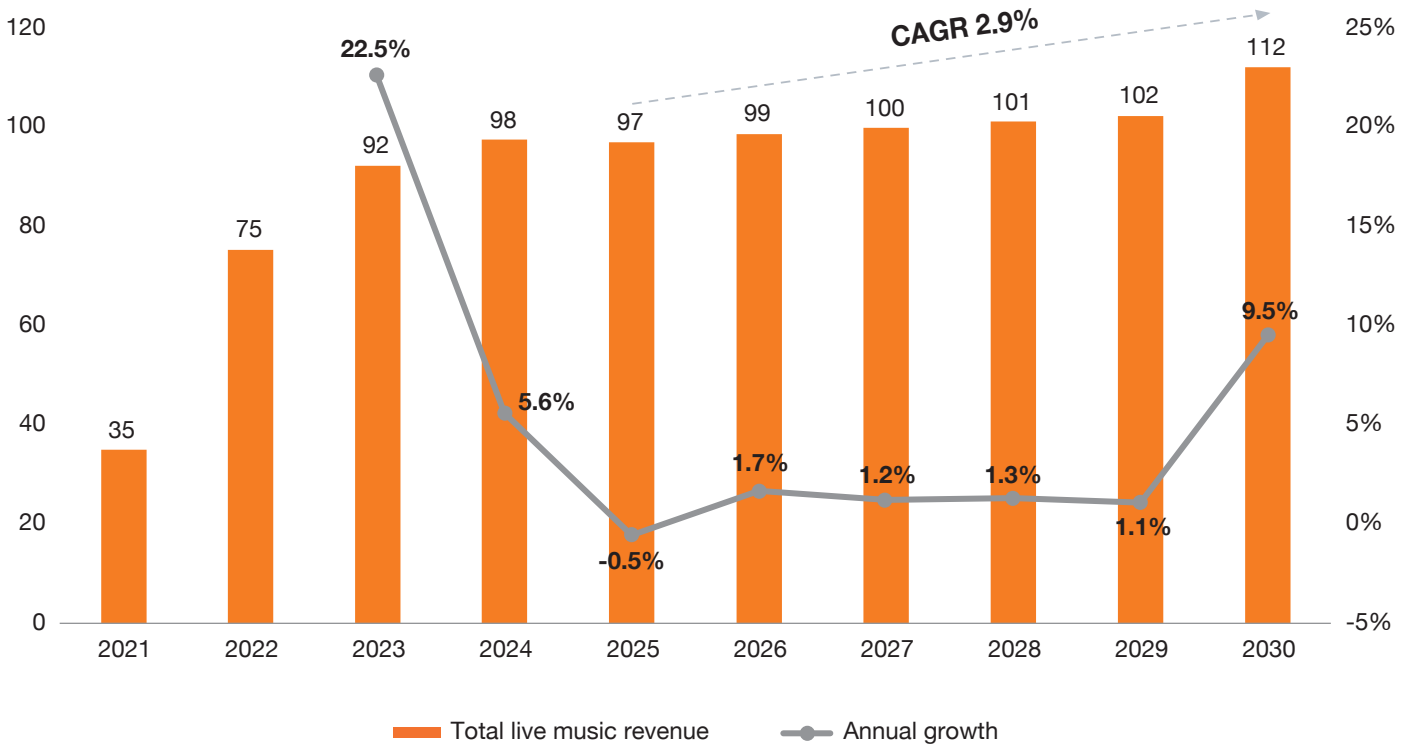
India’s live music market generated USD97.0 million in revenue in 2025 following a strong post-pandemic recovery driven by rising demand for experiential entertainment, growing event tourism, and the increasing presence of international artists. The market is expected to continue expanding, reaching USD112.1 million by 2030.

A defining trend within the sector is the rapid growth of premium ticketing, including VIP access, curated experiences, and hospitality packages. Premium ticket sales are estimated to have grown by more than 100% year-on-year, highlighting consumers’ willingness to spend more for exclusive and differentiated experiences rather than simply attending an event.

The economic impact of live music is also broadening. Large-scale concerts are becoming important contributors to local economies, with major events generating between 2,000 and 5,000 temporary jobs while supporting tourism, hospitality, and related services. This is transforming live music from a niche entertainment category into a meaningful component of India’s creative economy.

Moreover, industry stakeholders are seeking to position India as a regional hub for major international tours. Public-private partnership initiatives aimed at attracting global event operators such as AEG and Ticketmaster are helping strengthen the country’s live entertainment infrastructure and support the continued expansion of music tourism. The success of premium live experiences signals a broader shift across the entertainment industry: Audiences are increasingly willing to pay not just for content but also for memorable, immersive, and exclusive experiences that create deeper engagement and higher perceived value.

India: Live music revenue (in USD million) and annual growth (%), 2021–2030



A photograph of a movie theater interior. The foreground and middle ground are filled with rows of plush, red upholstered seats. The seats are arranged in a tiered fashion, facing towards the back of the frame. At the far end of the theater, a bright, circular light source, likely a projector or screen, glows with a strong blue and white light, creating a lens flare effect. The walls and ceiling of the theater are dark, making the red seats and the bright light stand out.

India's cinema industry is also increasingly benefiting from consumers' willingness to pay for premium theatrical experiences. Exhibitors are increasingly investing in premium large-format screens, advanced projection technologies, immersive sound systems, and luxury seating to enhance the viewing experience and increase per-capita spending. These premium formats continue to generate a disproportionate share of revenues, demonstrating that consumers are willing to pay more for a differentiated OOH entertainment experience.

As audiences seek higher-quality and more immersive experiences, spend per visit, rather than number of visits, is driving value creation in the cinema industry. This has led to the emergence of an attractive new revenue pool for exhibitors and content owners alike.

5.3 Accelerating the next phase of value creation through AI

From content discovery and production to advertising and audience engagement, AI is increasingly being deployed to improve efficiency, enhance personalisation, and create new monetisation opportunities. Moving beyond isolated AI use cases, the industrialisation of AI across media workflows and business models will usher in the next phase of value creation.

As consumers increasingly discover content through AI-powered interfaces rather than traditional search engines, media companies are adapting their content strategies accordingly. The emergence of generative engine optimisation (GEO) represents the next evolution of discoverability, shifting the focus from ranking highly in search results to becoming trusted sources that are cited within AI-generated responses.

Unlike traditional search optimisation, GEO focuses on structuring content so that it can be easily understood, validated, and surfaced by AI agents. The objective is to build authority and credibility within AI-driven ecosystems rather than simply generating clicks. This trend is already influencing business information providers and research organisations that are seeking to make proprietary content ‘AI-ready’ and increase their visibility across generative platforms. As AI-powered search and recommendation tools become more prevalent, discoverability will increasingly depend on whether content can be effectively indexed, interpreted, and referenced by AI systems.

In addition to how content is discovered, AI is transforming how it is created.

Content creation through AI

The cinema industry has integrated AI into production workflows to improve efficiency, reduce costs, and unlock new creative possibilities. AI is already being used for pre-visualisation, de-ageing, multilingual voice modelling, and production experimentation, helping filmmakers streamline workflows while managing rising production costs.

Several Indian productions have already deployed AI in mainstream production environments. Films such as Ghost used AI-assisted de-ageing and facial animation, while Coolie utilised AI-powered voice modelling to support multilingual releases. Other projects, including Chiranjeevi Hanuman: The Eternal, demonstrate the growing potential of AI-generated filmmaking.

Beyond cinema, AI is also beginning to reshape publishing and advertising. Publishers are adapting content structures for AI-driven discovery through GEO strategies, while OOH advertising players are investing in AI-led storytelling and content creation capabilities to support integrated campaigns across digital and physical channels. As these technologies mature, AI will increasingly support content creation, localisation, distribution, and optimisation across the broader E&M ecosystem.

Create	Distribute	Market	Monetise
AI-assisted production	GEO	AI-led storytelling	Audience targeting
Voice modelling	Content discoverability	Campaign optimisation	Advertising effectiveness
De-ageing and VFX	Multilingual localisation	Personalisation	Revenue optimisation
Virtual production	AI-powered recommendations	Creative generation	Consumer engagement



AI in audience engagement

The growing volume of digital content is making personalisation increasingly important. Across streaming, music, podcasts, and digital media, platforms are seeking to match content better with consumer preferences, improve engagement, and increase retention. AI-driven recommendation systems are becoming central to this process, helping platforms surface relevant content, improve discoverability, and deepen engagement. This is particularly important in India's highly fragmented media market, where consumers interact with content across multiple languages, formats, and platforms. As media companies seek to improve monetisation and retention, personalisation will become a critical competitive differentiator.

The rise of regional content consumption, personalised content journeys, and highly targeted advertising further reinforces the growing role AI will play in audience engagement across the sector.

Thus, as AI adoption accelerates, governance is becoming increasingly important. The widespread use of AI in content creation, voice modelling, production workflows, and discoverability raises important questions around

intellectual property, content ownership, transparency, and accountability. The growing integration of AI into production environments means media companies will need clear frameworks governing the use of AI-generated content and synthetic media.

The regulatory environment is also evolving. India's implementation of the Digital Personal Data Protection Act (DPDPA) strengthens consumer data protection and introduces more stringent requirements around consent, data management, and breach reporting. As AI systems become increasingly reliant on consumer and behavioural data, compliance and responsible data governance will become a critical business priority.

Ultimately, trust will be the defining currency of the AI era. Consumers, advertisers, and content creators will expect transparency in how AI is used, confidence that content remains credible, and assurance that intellectual property rights are protected. Organisations that can combine innovation with responsible AI practices will be best positioned to benefit from the industrialisation of AI across the E&M sector.

While last year's report highlighted the transformative potential of agentic AI in the E&M sector, this year's analysis reinforces AI's growing importance. As the industry's growth narrative evolves from scale to monetisation, responsible AI moves from being a strategic advantage to a business imperative, powering the future of value creation across the sector.

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Contact us

Rajesh Sethi

Partner and Leader, Media, Entertainment, and Sports

rajesh.sethi@pwc.com

Contributors

Vishnupriya Sengupta, Kamlesh Balasubramanian, Tarunay Dayal, Ruchika Uniyal

Editorial support

Dion D'Souza

Design

Harshpal Singh



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